means peaceful. One can imagine a situation akin to that faced by the Protestant settlers of New England in the seventeenth century, who initially had to rely on the Native American tribes for help to survive the harsh winters but then found themselves increasingly unwelcome as they expanded deeper into the interior. As in North America, so in Northern India, where the autochthonous peoples were also demonised as savages, so that the word *dasa* came to mean 'slave' or, more kindly, 'servant', but accompanied by such slighting epithets as *amanusah* ('sub-human'), *adhara* ('inferior'), *avratahas* ('without religious rites'), *krishnatvac* ('dark-skinned') and *anas* ('noseless', i.e. flat-nosed).

The Vedic religion was now evolving into a corpus of beliefs nowadays increasingly referred to as Vedanta, meaning 'the conclusion of the Vedas'. This was formalised from about 700 BCE onwards with the addition of a further tranche of spoken texts going under the generic term Dharmashastra, 'scriptures of universal order'. It was these later texts rather than the Vedas that laid the parameters of what we might now call Brahminical Hinduism. They also set out new ground rules for the proper ordering of society, enshrining into sacred law the born superiority of the ruling elite, taking their cue from four lines of verse in what is perhaps the most famous – or is it notorious? – hymn known as the *Purusha Sukta*, from *Rig-Veda* Book 10, which describes the division of the superman Purusha into four orders of men:

> *V. 11. When they divided Purusha how many portions did they make?*
> *What do they call his mouth and arms? What do they call his thighs and feet?*
> *V. 12. The Brahman was his mouth; of both his arms was the Rajanya [Kshatriyas] made.*
> *His thighs became the Vaishya; from his feet the Shudra was produced.*[26]